

For a few polygons more

Agent 001 sets out to satisfy his thirst for graphics cards

Unless you're a Zen master, who has found inner peace and is not perturbed by the insufficiencies of life, chances are you're looking for a new graphics card. Most games released today need a high-end card that lets you enjoy the immersive game environment to its fullest. My own excursion for the card was fuelled by a single-minded motive: I wanted to play *Medal of Honor* at a frame rate that didn't resemble a PowerPoint presentation.

My search for a better graphics card began with a *pan-chewing* dealer in Lamington Road, Mumbai. I was inquiring about the regular GeForces and Radeons, when he tried to sell me his 'best selling item'—an ASUS V3800, 32 MB RIVA TNT2 M64 for a bargain price of Rs 2,750! Now a Riva TNT2 M64 card can only play Real Time Strategy (RTS) games and OpenGL/Direct 3D games that are over two years old. Games like *Quake III*, *Counter-Strike*, *Soldier of Fortune* will play without a hitch on these cards, but for games like *Soldier of Fortune II*, *Medal of Honor* and *Return to Castle Wolfenstein*, you'll need at least an entry level GeForce card to see all those cool effects. Otherwise, you would have to scale down the graphics quality to such an extent that playing the game would just not be the fun it was meant to be.

Touched by my enthusiasm, one kind dealer let me ogle at an

ASUS AGP-V8460 Ultra 128 MB DDR, GeForce4 Ti4600 with TV-out, Video-in and DVI. I felt the textures of the box, and marvelled at the devastating power it held within, but my spirits sank when I heard the price—Rs 34,500! I put it down politely, and looked around for something more affordable. Much to my disappointment, I learnt that most dealers in Lamington Road didn't stock high-end cards such as the GeForce3—these were available only by order.

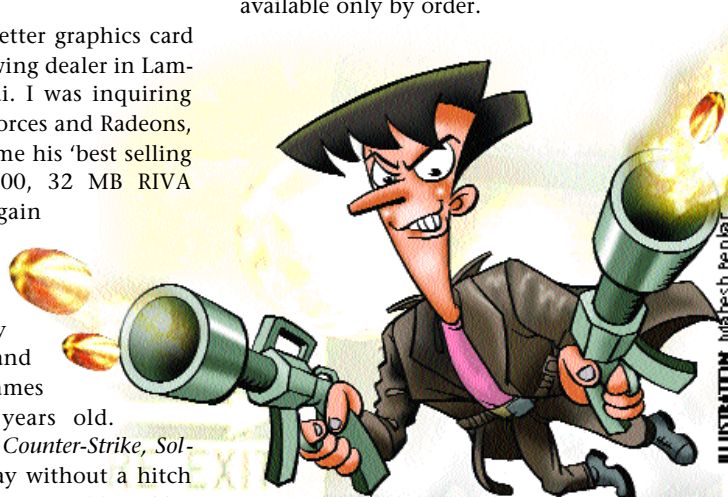
now, since the cards were in demand and would soon be out of stock. But my curiosity got the better of me and as I looked around, I found other cards that looked rather inviting. The ATi Radeon 8500 for Rs 15,500 is a good alternative to the nVidia cards and its performance is comparable to the GeForce3. The lower-end ATi Radeon VE 32 MB was available at a street price of Rs 3,500, while the ATi RAGE 128 was priced at Rs 2,500. As I

scoured longer, I found some more GeForce2 substitutes—the MSI make was available for Rs 4,365, while an MX200 card cost just Rs 2,800.

Graphics cards don't come in just the plain vanilla flavour anymore; there are many different versions available for each graphics chipset, each at varying price points. The GeForce4 chip itself has no less than six flavours (three each in the Ti and MX range). Also, manufacturers add funny sounding names like Ultra, Pure, Deluxe, Pro, VIVO, etc to their cards to highlight additional features like higher memory speeds, TV tuner capability, FM radio, Video-out, VR glasses, etc. Sounds confusing? It is!

Most games today need 32 MB of video RAM, unless you want to play at a resolution of 1024x768 (at 32-bit colour) or higher. The GeForce2 MX is ideal because it's cheap (cheaper than the GeForce DDR cards) and suited to most games available today. It proves to be almost as fast as the GeForce DDR (Double Data Rate) and faster than a GeForce SDR (Single Data Rate memory). This card will also pull you through the year until *DOOM III*'s release makes every card in the market obsolete!

The key to buying the right card is to inquire about the different manufacturers at various dealers. Prices vary between manufacturers because each uses different specifications like core and RAM speeds. My wallet being slightly handicapped, I called it a day by settling for the GeForce2 MX card from HIS, after bargaining off a couple of hundred rupees. 



A trek further down to Andheri in the western suburbs yielded a goldmine. Here, the Pine 64 MB SDRAM GeForce2 MX400 came at the heart-warming price of Rs 3,500 and Maxtone's GeForce2 MX400 cost just Rs 3,000! The cards came unaccompanied by any frills like bundled software and forfeited the cooling fans. The dealer advised me to make my choice



■ Your choice of graphics card will depend heavily upon the kind of games you play. If you are into the latest First Person Shooters (FPS) and 3D gaming, a powerful card like the GeForce2 GTS is necessary. For strategy, adventure and 2D games, a simple RIVA TNT2 would suffice.
■ Choose the card that best suits your processor. If your processor is slower than 700 MHz, then a GeForce2 MX is recommended. But if your system is faster than 900 MHz, you could opt for a GeForce2 Pro with 32 MB of video memory.

■ Check if your motherboard has an AGP slot and supports AGP 4x before buying a GeForce-level card.
■ Buy within your budget, since there are enough flavours for every graphics chipset to suit you and you will probably be tempted to upgrade as soon as a new game comes out.
■ The performance of a graphics card varies from manufacturer to manufacturer, so check performance benchmarks before making your buying decision.